was viewed more positively. That the West had also put such a premium on China inevitably influenced the thinking of both India and Japan.

China may have preoccupied India and Japan over many years in different ways. But they were even more transfixed by other immediate neighbours with whom ties were particularly difficult. One had Pakistan, the other North Korea. As a result, India and Japan coexisted harmoniously but distantly, each in the midst of their own preoccupations. Neither saw the other as contributing to their search for solutions. Until, of course, the challenges of a volatile world created by shifting balances of power became so large that the problem itself was redefined.

When India decided to look more to the East a quarter century ago, it was the beginning of a profound correction in its foreign policy. The Western bias that was an outcome of its colonial past was strengthened by the prevailing global scenario. The two superpowers – the US and USSR – were both faces of that Western world, even if they represented competing forces. Europe also occupied a very prominent place in Indian thinking and the collective influence of the West was visible in politics, economics and security. The 1991 crisis, however, changed India's model of development and made it look more towards Asian economic growth of relatively recent origin. ASEAN served as a path of entry into this new syndrome and its institutions helped socialize India into a different world.

Since then, India's interface with South-East Asia and East Asia has grown steadily. Its economic collaborations with Japan, South Korea and China have expanded under all governments. This was also a period when Asia in general, and China in particular, was gaining greater global clout. Later, the repositioning of American power and the re-emergence of Japan were also factors to be taken into account. What started as an economic correction in India increasingly factored in these political developments and ended up more as a strategic one. Whether it is activities, transactions, challenges or attention, the centre of gravity for India has shifted much more to the East. That explains the necessity of Indo-Pacific as a working principle. India was always India, but its modern sense of being Asia has developed more strongly by looking and acting eastwards.